

Chapter 15

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- A brief history of formal policies that target Asian populations
- American knowledge of Asia and American perceptions of Asians and Asian Americans
- Stereotypes of Asians and Asian accents, including a discussion of the perpetual foreigner syndrome and the model minority stereotype
- A discussion of mockery of Asian accents
- A discussion of Rosie O'Donnell's use of an ethnic slur on *The View* and her non-apology in response to public criticism of her remarks.
- University students' reaction to teaching assistants with Asian accents

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. Consider the series of court rulings beginning in 1883 that led to the shutdown of all immigration from China for about sixty years. Look also at the related rulings that made it illegal to grant Asians naturalized citizenship. In that broader context, read the story of Bhagat Singh Thind, who came to the U.S. in 1917. What were the long-range repercussions of the Supreme Court decision that sent him back to Punjab? In linguistic terms, how factual was the Court's definition of Indo-European? The website: <http://goo.gl/UhEvv>

Sample answer: The Supreme Court decision in this case caused other immigrants from India who had already become citizens to be stripped of their citizenship. It also further restricted the definition of "white," which led to even more exclusionary citizenship laws. In terms of its definition of Indo-European, the Court recognizes that many modern languages of Europe and the Middle East can trace their ancestry back to a common language, but the Court seems to envision this ancestor language as a language of white people. Also, it seems to be suggested that perhaps some groups (I would suspect they would say the Middle Eastern groups) learned Proto-Indo-European as a second language from another group, rather than entertaining the possibility that all the Indo-European languages grew from a common source (which would suggest the people who speak those languages came from a common source population).

2. Look closely at Table 15.2 adapted from the Derwing et al (2002) experiment. What conclusions can you draw from these figures? How do the three control groups compare to each other? Consider differences between the first and second groups, and then compare them to the third group. On this evidence alone, what measures seemed to be most effective in alleviating communication stumbling blocks? Argue for or against the proposition that all first year college students should be required to participate in an orientation session that addresses communication issues such as these.

Sample answer: From examining this table, it looks like the accent instruction group gained the most from the experiment, followed by the familiarity group, and the control group did not

change much. However, it is interesting to me that the control group started out with a more positive approach to foreign accents than either the familiarity or accent instruction groups. In fact, the accent instruction group had such a negative approach to foreign accents that the experiment brought them up to be comparable to the control group. But, even so, it is definitely progress. Based on these findings alone, it seems that accent instruction is the most effective strategy to alleviate communication stumbling blocks. I think it would be a good idea to implement an orientation to introduce students to the general strategies for understanding L2 accents and being a good listener. Then perhaps students could have access to resources to help educate them about the features of particular L2 accents based on the needs they might have each quarter or semester. If the findings of Derwin *et al.*'s research are generalizable, then this kind of accent instruction could improve communication, which will mean happier students and happier teaching assistants.

3. *In 2005, a student of Asian heritage applied to Princeton. He had an excellent academic history and hit all the usual marks for admission, but he was not admitted. He enrolled at Yale, and shortly thereafter filed a lawsuit against Princeton for discrimination on the basis of national origin. In the following spring, a column appeared in The Daily Princetonian, the campus newspaper. A short excerpt:*

“Hi Princeton! Remember me? I so good at math and science. Perfect 2400 SAT score. Ring Bells? Just in case, let me refresh your memories. I the super smart Asian. Princeton the super dumb college, not accept me.”

What is the purpose of writing this in what is supposed to be the plaintiff's own language? What underlying beliefs and ideologies might be informing it?

Sample answer: The purpose of writing this in what is supposed to be the plaintiff's own language is to mock him. This statement plays on the model minority stereotype of Asians being very smart, especially in math and science, and it also uses a mock Asian L2 accent that trivializes the plaintiff and English learners of Asian descent.

4. *How aware were you, before reading this chapter, of how offensive “ching-chong” is as an ethnic slur. How did you react to this information? If you felt any irritation, can you get to the bottom of that, and figure out where it comes from? If you are Asian, what are your experiences with this term? Have you ever talked to non-Asians about the impact this term has? Why or why not?*

Sample answer: I did consider mocking Asian languages offensive before reading this chapter, but I did not realize that the term *ching-chong* itself had an offensive meaning as an ethnic slur. I reacted to this information with dismay, especially since Rosie O'Donnell refused to offer a full apology for using the offensive term, whether or not she recognized it as an ethnic slur when she said it.

5. *If you are Asian and you are willing to volunteer to answer questions, please let your instructor know. It would be especially helpful if you were willing to talk to the other students*

about the various viewpoints in this chapter, and whether you agree or disagree with conclusions drawn.

Sample answer: Questions and answers will vary.

6. *To test your own knowledge of Asia, try the quiz you'll find here:*
<http://www.mccollam.com/fun/geoquiz/asiaquiz.html>

Sample answer: Individual experiences will vary.

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the samples of the accents mentioned in Chapter 15 and revisit the discussion of how university students react to teaching assistants with L2 accents. Have you ever heard fellow students complaining about a teaching assistant with any of these accents? Others? Why do you think some accents get complained about more than others?

Sample answer: I have only heard other students complaining about Asian accents (usually with no specification of what the teaching assistant's L1 was) and once I heard someone complaining about a teaching assistant with a German accent. I think the primary reason that Asian accents get complained about more than European accents is because Asian accents are not as highly valued as European accents, so students aren't as committed to trying to understand Asian accents.

Video

"Rush Limbaugh Mocks Chinese President"

ABC News, 1/20/2011

<http://abcnews.go.com/Politics/video/rush-limbaugh-mocks-chinese-president-hu-jintao-12721187>

1. Compare and contrast this clip to Rosie O'Donnell's use of fake Chinese on The View discussed in Chapter 15. What do the similarities and differences indicate about the language ideologies behind the use of fake Chinese for both media personalities?

Sample answer: Both Rosie O'Donnell and Rush Limbaugh used fake Chinese for the purpose of mocking humor, and they both used "ching chong" in their fake Chinese utterance. This type of mocking illustrates a language ideology that sees Chinese as a language fit to be mocked and trivialized through this kind of humor. In addition, neither media personality was truly apologetic about their mocking use of fake Chinese, which illustrates an underlying belief that they have the right to trivialize the Chinese language. There are also a few differences between these two uses of mock Chinese. First of all, Rosie O'Donnell's use of fake Chinese does not seem to be as focused on the language and speakers itself as Rush Limbaugh's mocking use of fake Chinese. Rosie O'Donnell's joke was focused on how Danny DeVito had made such an international fool

of himself by appearing on the show drunk that people around the world were talking about it' however, in trying to make that joke she belittled Chinese and used offensive ethnic slurs. Rush Limbaugh's entire joke was that Chinese—as spoken by the Chinese president—is ridiculous. Based on that difference, I think that Rush Limbaugh feels more entitled to belittle and trivialize foreign languages.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Revisit the case of the Filipino security guards who were fired because of a single complaint about an employee's accent and consider this quote from page 287:

The Filipino security guards won their lawsuit, but a question was never raised: how was it that an anonymous official could bring about the removal of five men with solid work histories, solely on the basis of an unsubstantiated claim of an irritating and distracting accent? If the guards in question had been Italian or Norwegian speakers, would the same progression of events be imaginable?

Ask your students how they would answer these questions and why they feel the way they do.

2. Ask your students if they have ever heard someone mock an Asian language or an Asian accent in real life. What was the context and what message did the speaker intend to convey with his or her mockery? What does this reveal about language ideologies and language attitudes?

3. Ask your students what they think about the stereotype of Asian Americans as the “model minority” and any other “positive” stereotypes of Asians and Asian Americans. Do they think “positive” stereotypes are good or bad? Or both? Why do they feel the way they do?

4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.